

See also: The Glorious Revolution and the English Bill of Rights 102–103 ■ The US Constitution and Bill of Rights 110–117
 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229 ■ The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights 256–257



Former British prime minister

Winston Churchill was the honorary president of the Congress of Europe at The Hague, in the Netherlands, in 1948.

democracy, could be used to guard the region against communism and totalitarianism.

The 10 founding states of the Council of Europe were Belgium, Denmark, France, Ireland, Italy, the Netherlands, Luxembourg, Norway, Sweden, and the UK. Delegates debated issues such as whether the emergency powers within the new Convention might be used to abuse human rights. Britain and France also worried that some independence movements in their respective colonies might use the Convention against them.

There was much debate about whether to create a court to enforce the new human rights convention.

Some nations did not understand how such a court would work, while others were more concerned about the scope of its powers.

The final text of the Convention was completed in 1950. It opened for signature in the same year and came into force in 1953, after being ratified by the Council of Europe's 10 founding states; other states signed up over the next 50 years. Once a sufficient number of member states had ratified the ECHR, the European Court of Human Rights (ECtHR) was set up in Strasbourg, France. The Court consists of a lower court and an appeals chamber, and it heard its first case in 1959.

When states sign up to the Convention, they must, under Article 1, protect the Convention rights for everyone in their country or otherwise under their control. If they do not, a person living in that »

You are living in the **territory** of a country that has **signed** the **European Convention on Human Rights**.



You are a victim of a **human rights abuse** because a **government** has **denied** you a **Convention right**.



You have **tried to resolve** your **complaint** in your **own country** without success.



Your **complaint** is **of a sort** that has **not previously** been **resolved** by the European Court of Human Rights.



You are eligible to have your case heard in the European Court of Human Rights.